

W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG 2.1) Implementation Manual

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Principle 1 & 2: Perceivable and Operable User Interfaces

WCAG 2.1 covers a wide range of recommendations for making web content accessible to individuals with disabilities.

The guidelines are structured around four POUR principles: Perceivable, Operable, Understandable, and Robust.

Success Criterion 1.1.1 (Non-text Content) mandates providing text alternatives for any non-text visual content such as information.

Guideline 2.1 mandates that all functionality must be operable through a keyboard interface without requiring a mouse or pointer.

Criterion 2.1.2 ensures no keyboard traps exist, allowing keyboard users to navigate into and out of all interactive components.

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Principle 3: Understandable and Contrast Ratio Requirements

Success Criterion 1.4.3 (Contrast Minimum) requires a visual contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 for standard text and images of text.

For large-scale text (defined as 18 point or 14 point bold), the minimum required contrast ratio is 3:1 at Level AA conformance.

Criterion 3.1.1 mandates identifying the default human language of each web page programmatically using the HTML lang attribute.

Form fields require clear text labels or instructions under Criterion 3.3.2, with descriptive error identification upon failed validation.

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Principle 4: Robust Technical Implementation and Conformance Levels

Principle 4 requires content to be robust enough to be interpreted reliably by diverse user agents, including screen readers.

HTML markup must avoid duplicate attributes, ensure properly nested elements, and include unique id attributes across active elements.

WCAG establishes three conformance levels: Level A (minimum foundational accessibility), Level AA (standard compliance target), and Level AAA (enhanced accessibility).

Most government and institutional accessibility compliance mandates specify Level AA conformance across all public web portals and digital services.